Ascend Coaching



THE RECOMP BLUEPRINT

How to build muscle and burn fat at the same time: your calories, macros, training, cardio and food, set up step by step.

ASCEND COACHING GUIDE · 2026 EDITION

General fitness and nutrition education, not medical advice. Talk to your doctor before changing your diet or training if you have a medical condition. Information current as of November 2026.

CHAPTER 1

01 My recomp story

Out of every method I've tried, body recomposition gave me the best results. It was slower, but it was worth it.

I was able to lose fat and put on muscle while staying at my maintenance calories. No crash diet, no miserable bulk. Just eating right, training hard and being patient.

My biggest mistake

I was eating at maintenance, but I wasn't eating as well as I could. My calories were "right", but my protein and food quality were all over the place. It wasn't until I started actually prioritizing my macros, consistently, that I started to see results that made it worth it.

Why recomp is my favorite method

- **You still feel good.** Grinding down to stage-lean through long, aggressive diets can tank your energy, your mood and your testosterone. On a recomp you keep your energy up the whole time.
- **You don't have to shrink to get lean.** Recomp let me stay at a heavier bodyweight while getting leaner, so I looked better without looking smaller.
- **It's sustainable.** Eating at maintenance means you can actually live your life while you make progress.

It didn't click overnight

There wasn't one specific moment where it all clicked for me. It was seeing progress over time: from the first month to the third, then the fifth. Every check-in, my photos looked a little better than the last. That is what recomp looks like, and that is why this guide is built around tracking.

> **How to use this guide:** read it once start to finish, then set yourself up using Chapters 3 to 7. Use Chapter 8 every week to track, and Chapter 9 to adjust. Follow it for at least 12 weeks before you judge it.

CHAPTER 2

02 What a recomp actually is

Body recomposition means losing fat and building muscle at the same time, so your body changes even if the scale barely moves.

The old advice was that you have to pick one: bulk to build muscle, then cut to lose fat. Research now shows that a lot of people can do both at once, as long as protein is high, training is hard and progressive, and calories are close to maintenance.

Who it works best for

GREAT FIT

Beginners

New lifters respond fastest. Your first year of real training is the best recomp window you will ever have.

GREAT FIT

Returning lifters

If you trained before and took time off, muscle comes back quickly ("muscle memory").

GREAT FIT

Skinny fat or a bit soft

Some extra fat to use as fuel plus room to add muscle is the perfect setup.

WORKS, BUT SLOWER

Experienced and lean

The leaner and more trained you are, the slower recomp gets. It still works, just expect smaller monthly changes.

CONSIDER A CUT FIRST

A lot of fat to lose

If fat loss is your main goal, a small deficit (Chapter 3) gets you there faster while you still build muscle.

CONSIDER A BULK

Very lean, want size

If you're already lean and want to get bigger fast, a slow lean bulk will build more muscle.

The four things that make it work

- **Calories at maintenance** (or a small deficit), so you're not storing extra fat.
- **High protein, every day,** so your body has the material to build muscle.
- **Hard, progressive lifting,** so your body has a reason to build muscle.
- **Sleep, steps and patience,** so you recover and give it time to show.

> **Reality check:** recomp is slower than a bulk or a cut. Your scale might move less than a pound a month. Judge it by your waist, your photos and your lifts, not your bodyweight.

CHAPTER 3

03 Find your maintenance calories

Maintenance is the number of calories that keeps your weight steady. Everything in this guide is built on it, so it's worth getting right.

1. **Work out your BMR (calories burned at rest)**
   Use the Mifflin-St Jeor equation, the most accurate everyday formula for most people:

   ```
   Men: (10 × weight in kg) + (6.25 × height in cm) − (5 × age) + 5
   Women: (10 × weight in kg) + (6.25 × height in cm) − (5 × age) − 161
   ```

   lb ÷ 2.2 = kg · inches × 2.54 = cm

2. **Multiply by your activity level**
   Light ×1.375: desk job, lifting 3 to 4 days a week, under about 7,000 steps. **Moderate ×1.55:** lifting 4 to 6 days, 8,000 to 10,000 steps (most people running this plan). **Very active ×1.725:** on your feet all day, or training 6 days plus cardio and 10,000+ steps.

3. **Run it for 2 to 3 weeks and adjust**
   Weigh yourself every morning and compare weekly averages. If your average is going up, drop 100 to 200 calories. If it's dropping, add 100 to 200. When the average holds steady, that is your real maintenance.

Example: a 25-year-old man, 5'10", 180 lb (81.6 kg, 177.8 cm), lifting 5 days with 8,000+ steps.
BMR = 816 + 1,111 − 125 + 5 = **1,807** → 1,807 × 1.55 = **about 2,800 calories a day** to start.

EDWIN'S TIP

My own maintenance sits around 3,000 calories, because I'm very active and carry a good amount of muscle. Yours could be a lot higher or lower. Don't copy my number, find yours.

CHAPTER 3 · CHART

Maintenance calorie chart

Find the row closest to your height and weight to get a starting number. All examples are worked out with Mifflin-St Jeor at age 25 and rounded to the nearest 50.

Men

Height	Weight	BMR	Light ×1.375	Moderate ×1.55	Very active ×1.725
5′6″	150 lb	1,600	2,200	**2,500**	2,750
5′7″	165 lb	1,700	2,350	**2,600**	2,900
5′8″	170 lb	1,750	2,400	**2,700**	3,000
5′10″	180 lb	1,800	2,500	**2,800**	3,100
5′10″	200 lb	1,900	2,600	**2,950**	3,250
6′0″	190 lb	1,900	2,600	**2,900**	3,250
6′0″	210 lb	2,000	2,700	**3,050**	3,400
6′2″	220 lb	2,050	2,800	**3,200**	3,550

Women

Height	Weight	BMR	Light ×1.375	Moderate ×1.55	Very active ×1.725
5′2″	120 lb	1,250	1,700	**1,950**	2,150
5′4″	135 lb	1,350	1,850	**2,100**	2,300
5′5″	150 lb	1,450	1,950	**2,200**	2,450
5′7″	160 lb	1,500	2,050	**2,350**	2,600
5′8″	175 lb	1,600	2,200	**2,450**	2,750

Older or younger than 25? Take off about 75 calories for every 10 years older, or add about 75 for every 10 years younger. These are estimates: formulas can be off by 10% or more for any one person, especially if you carry a lot of muscle. Your 2 to 3 weeks of weigh-ins always beat the chart.

Option: a small deficit

If you have a fair amount of fat to lose and want it to come off a bit faster, set calories **200 to 300 below** maintenance. Don’t go further than that. A bigger deficit makes building muscle much harder and starts costing you energy and strength.

CHAPTER 4

04 Set your macros

Calories decide whether you gain or lose weight. Macros decide whether that weight is muscle or fat. This is the part I got wrong at first.

PRIORITY 1

Protein

0.8 to 1 g per lb of bodyweight, every day. If you have a lot of fat to lose, use your goal weight instead.

PRIORITY 2

Fat

0.3 to 0.4 g per lb. Enough to keep hormones and energy healthy. Don't drop much below this.

THE REST

Carbs

Whatever calories are left. Carbs fuel your training, so don't fear them.

Worked example: 180 lb at 2,800 calories

Macro	How	Grams	Calories
Protein	1 g × 180 lb	180 g	720
Fat	0.36 g × 180 lb	65 g	585
Carbs	(2,800 − 720 − 585) ÷ 4	375 g	1,495

Protein and carbs have 4 calories per gram. Fat has 9.

Hit protein first, every single day

Research puts the benefit of protein for building muscle at around 0.7 to 1 g per lb, which is exactly where this range sits. Spread it over 3 to 5 meals with 30 to 50 g each. Protein is also the most filling macro, which makes maintenance calories a lot easier to stick to.

EDWIN'S TIP

Eating maintenance isn't enough on its own. I was at the right calories for a while and barely changed. Once I started hitting my macros consistently, not just some days, that's when the results came.

CHAPTER 5

05 The training plan

Five days a week: Push, Pull, Legs, then Upper and Lower. Every muscle gets trained twice a week, with abs and a 20-minute incline walk three times a week.

MON	TUE	WED	THU	FRI	SAT	SUN
Push + abs + walk	Pull	Legs + abs + walk	Rest	Upper + abs + walk	Lower	Rest

Brand new to lifting? Run Push, Pull, Legs once a week (Mon, Wed, Fri) for your first 1 to 2 months, then move to the full 5 days.

How to train each set

- **Effort:** finish each set with 1 to 2 good reps left in the tank. The last set of each exercise can go to failure on machines and cables.
- **Rest:** 2 to 3 minutes on big lifts (bench, squat, rows), 60 to 90 seconds on smaller ones.
- **Form first:** control the weight down, full range of motion, no ego lifting.

How to progress: double progression

Every exercise has a rep range, like 8 to 10. Pick a weight you can do for 8. Each week, try to add a rep. Once you hit the top of the range on every set, add weight (about 5 lb on upper body, 10 lb on lower body) and work back up from the bottom. Write every session down. If your lifts are going up, you are building muscle.

EDWIN'S TIP

Working out more doesn't necessarily mean it's better. Muscle grows while you recover, not while you train. If you keep hitting the same muscle groups while they're still sore and beat up, they never get the time to repair and replenish. That's why this plan has 2 rest days and gives every muscle at least 3 days before you train it again. A little soreness is fine to train through. Really sore and weaker than last time means give it another day.

Every day, every exercise

Push day (chest, shoulders, triceps)

Exercise	Sets × reps	Or swap for
Barbell bench press	3 × 6–8	Incline barbell press
Incline dumbbell press	3 × 8–10	Machine chest press
Seated dumbbell shoulder press	3 × 8–10	Machine shoulder press
Cable lateral raise	3 × 12–15	Dumbbell lateral raise
Rope triceps pushdown	3 × 10–12	Dips
Overhead cable triceps extension	2 × 12–15	EZ-bar skull crusher

Pull day (back, rear delts, biceps)

Exercise	Sets × reps	Or swap for
Pull-up or lat pulldown	3 × 6–10	Neutral-grip pulldown
Chest-supported row	3 × 8–10	Barbell row
Seated cable row	3 × 10–12	Single-arm dumbbell row
Face pull	3 × 12–15	Reverse pec deck
EZ-bar curl	3 × 8–10	Incline dumbbell curl
Hammer curl	2 × 10–12	Cable curl

Leg day (quads, hamstrings, glutes, calves)

Exercise	Sets × reps	Or swap for
Back squat	3 × 6–8	Hack squat
Romanian deadlift	3 × 8–10	Hip thrust
Leg press	3 × 10–12	Bulgarian split squat
Lying leg curl	3 × 10–12	Seated leg curl
Leg extension	2 × 12–15	Same
Standing calf raise	4 × 10–15	Seated calf raise

CHAPTER 5 · WORKOUTS

Upper, lower and abs

Upper day (chest, back, shoulders, arms)

Exercise	Sets × reps	Or swap for
Incline dumbbell press	3 × 8–10	Machine chest press
Chest-supported row	3 × 8–10	Seated cable row
Seated dumbbell shoulder press	3 × 8–10	Machine shoulder press
Lat pulldown	3 × 10–12	Pull-up
Cable lateral raise	3 × 12–15	Dumbbell lateral raise
EZ-bar curl + rope pushdown (superset)	2 × 10–12 each	Dumbbell curl + dips

Lower day (quads, hamstrings, glutes, calves)

Exercise	Sets × reps	Or swap for
Hack squat or leg press	3 × 8–10	Back squat
Romanian deadlift	3 × 8–10	Hip thrust
Bulgarian split squat	3 × 10–12 each leg	Walking lunge
Seated leg curl	3 × 10–12	Lying leg curl
Leg extension	2 × 12–15	Sissy squat
Seated calf raise	4 × 10–15	Standing calf raise

Abs (Mon, Wed, Fri, at the end of your lift)

Exercise	Sets × reps	Or swap for
Hanging knee or leg raise	3 × 10–15	Captain’s chair raise
Cable crunch	3 × 12–15	Weighted decline crunch
Plank	3 × 30–60 sec	Ab wheel rollout, 3 × 8–12

No access to a machine? Swap in the closest free-weight or cable version that hits the same muscle.

CHAPTER 6

06 Cardio, steps and sleep

On a recomp, cardio is there to support fat loss and health, not to replace your diet. Keep it simple and keep it easy to recover from.

3 TIMES A WEEK

20 min

Incline treadmill walk after your Mon, Wed and Fri lift.

THE SETTINGS

10–12%

Incline at 3.0 to 3.5 mph. Breathing harder, but you could still talk.

EVERY DAY

8–10k

Steps. The easiest way to burn more without hurting recovery.

Why incline walking

- It burns a good number of calories without beating up your joints or your legs for the next leg day.
- It's easy to recover from, so it doesn't eat into your strength gains.
- It's simple to stay consistent with. Put on a podcast and go.

Don't hold the rails. Holding on takes a lot of the work away. If you need to hold on, lower the incline until you don't.

Why steps matter

Your daily steps can change how many calories you burn by hundreds per day, and large studies link 8,000 to 10,000 steps a day with better long-term health. Walk after meals, take calls on foot, park further away. Keep your steps about the same every day so your maintenance stays stable.

Don't skip sleep

In one well-known study, dieters sleeping 5.5 hours lost far more muscle and less fat than the same people sleeping 8.5 hours, on the same diet. Aim for 7 to 9 hours. It's the cheapest recomp tool there is.

EDWIN'S TIP

Keep your cardio boring and consistent. I do the same 20-minute incline walk every time, right after I lift. It's short enough that I never skip it and easy enough that it never takes away from my next session. Throw on a podcast and the 20 minutes flies by.

CHAPTER 7

07 What to eat

No strict meal plan. Hit your calories and macros with foods you actually like, and build most meals around a protein source.

Build every meal the same way

- **A palm-to-hand-sized protein:** chicken, lean beef, fish, eggs and egg whites, Greek yogurt, protein shakes.
- **A carb for energy:** rice, potatoes, oats, pasta, bread, fruit.
- **Veggies or fruit:** for fiber, fullness and micronutrients.
- **A bit of fat:** olive oil, avocado, nuts, cheese. Easy to overdo, so measure it.

Aim for about 80% whole, simple foods and leave 20% for foods you enjoy. As long as your calories and protein are on point, that 20% won't hold you back.

> **EDWIN'S TIP**
>
> My go-tos: Diet Coke, since it's 0 calories and kills a sweet craving. Drinking water religiously. And protein-based snacks like Barebells protein bars and Fairlife protein shakes. Those did wonders for my cravings.

My go-to snacks

Snack	About	Why it helps
Barebells protein bar	200 kcal · 20 g protein	Tastes like a candy bar, and fits your macros.
Fairlife protein shake	150 kcal · 30 g protein	Grab-and-go, ready to drink, very filling.
Diet Coke / zero-sugar soda	0 kcal	Handles a sweet craving for free. Fine in moderation.
Water	0 kcal	Aim for a big glass with every meal and keep a bottle on you all day.

Numbers are approximate and vary by flavor. Always check the label.

CHAPTER 7 · SAMPLE DAYS

Two sample days

Use these as templates, not rules. Scale the carb and fat portions up or down to hit your own calorie number from Chapter 3.

Day 1: around 2,400 calories

Breakfast	3 whole eggs + 1 cup egg whites, 2 slices toast, 1 cup berries	565 kcal · 51P / 48C / 17F
Lunch	6 oz chicken breast, 1.5 cups cooked white rice, 1 cup veggies, 1 tbsp olive oil	760 kcal · 60P / 78C / 20F
Snack	Barebells protein bar + an apple + Diet Coke	295 kcal · 20P / 43C / 8F
Dinner	6 oz cooked 93% lean ground beef, 8 oz potato, side salad with light dressing	620 kcal · 50P / 51C / 23F
Evening	Fairlife protein shake	150 kcal · 30P / 4C / 3F

≈ 2,390 kcal **211 g protein** **224 g carbs** **71 g fat**

Day 2: around 2,850 calories

Breakfast	Overnight oats: 1 cup oats, 1 scoop whey, 1 cup Fairlife 2% milk, 1 tbsp peanut butter, 1 banana	740 kcal · 52P / 93C / 19F
Lunch	Burrito bowl: 6 oz chicken, 1.5 cups rice, ½ cup black beans, salsa, ¼ avocado, 1 oz cheese	890 kcal · 73P / 95C / 20F
Snack	1 cup nonfat Greek yogurt + ⅓ cup granola + Diet Coke	280 kcal · 27P / 31C / 6F
Dinner	6 oz salmon, 1.5 cups cooked pasta, 1.5 cups broccoli	730 kcal · 54P / 75C / 23F
Snack	Barebells protein bar	200 kcal · 20P / 18C / 8F

≈ 2,840 kcal **226 g protein** **312 g carbs** **76 g fat**

Track it: for at least the first 8 weeks, log everything in an app like MyFitnessPal, MacroFactor or Cronometer, and weigh your food. Oils, sauces, drinks and weekend meals are where most hidden calories come from.

CHAPTER 8

08 Track your progress

On a recomp the scale lies to you. Muscle going up and fat going down can cancel out on the scale, so you need better ways to measure.

EVERY MORNING

Bodyweight

After the bathroom, before food. Only look at the weekly average.

ONCE A WEEK

Waist

Tape around your belly button, relaxed, same day each week.

EVERY 4 WEEKS

Photos

Front, side, back. Same lighting, same spot, same time of day.

EVERY SESSION

Your lifts

Weights and reps going up is your proof that you're building muscle.

DAILY

Protein and calories

Were you on target? Count how many days out of 7.

DAILY

Sleep and steps

7 to 9 hours of sleep and 8,000 to 10,000 steps.

What to expect

Weeks 1 to 4
Strength goes up quickly. The scale may jump around from water and food in your gut. Don't panic.

Months 2 to 3
Clothes start fitting differently and your waist starts coming down while your lifts keep climbing.

Months 4 to 6
The changes become obvious in side-by-side photos. This is where recomp really pays off.

EDWIN'S TIP

Take the photos even when you don't feel like it. For me there was no single moment where it all clicked. It was comparing month one to month three, then month five, that showed me how far I'd come.

CHAPTER 9

09 When and how to adjust

Check your numbers every 2 weeks, not every day. Then use this table. Only change one thing at a time.

What you see (over 2+ weeks)	What it means	What to do
Weight steady, waist down, lifts up	Textbook recomp	**Change nothing.** Keep going.
Weight up, waist up	You're above maintenance	Drop 150 to 200 calories, mostly from carbs or fat.
Weight dropping fast (over 0.5% a week), lifts stalling or dropping	You're in too big a deficit	Add 150 to 200 calories, mostly from carbs.
Weight, waist and lifts all flat for 4+ weeks	Something isn't on point	Check protein, tracking, sleep and progression first. If all are good, drop 150 calories or add 2,000 daily steps.
Always hungry and low energy	Calories or protein too low, or poor food choices	Check you're hitting protein, eat more high-volume foods, and recheck your maintenance.

Common recomp mistakes

- **Eating "maintenance" but ignoring macros.** The right calories with low protein won't build much muscle. (This was my mistake.)
- **Guessing instead of tracking.** Eyeballed portions, cooking oils, drinks and weekends add up fast.
- **Living on the scale.** A flat scale on a recomp can mean everything is working.
- **Lifting the same weights for months.** No progression means no reason for your body to build muscle.
- **Changing the plan every week.** Give each change at least 2 weeks before you judge it.
- **Too much cardio or cutting calories too hard.** That turns a recomp into a regular diet and costs you muscle.
- **Skimping on sleep.** Under 7 hours makes everything harder.

CHAPTER 10

10 Your weekly checklist

Hit these every week and the results take care of themselves.

- [ ] Calories within 100 of my target at least 6 days out of 7
- [ ] Protein at 0.8 to 1 g per lb every day
- [ ] All 5 lifting sessions done and logged
- [ ] Beat last week on at least one exercise per workout (a rep or more weight)
- [ ] Abs and a 20-minute incline walk, 3 times
- [ ] 8,000 to 10,000 steps a day
- [ ] 7 to 9 hours of sleep most nights
- [ ] Weighed in every morning and worked out my weekly average
- [ ] Measured my waist
- [ ] Progress photos (every 4th week)

> **Remember:** recomp is a slow burn. Run this plan for at least 12 weeks, judge it by your photos, waist and lifts, and adjust with the table in Chapter 9.

Want me to build it for you?

At **Ascend Coaching**, a real coach with 9 years of training experience builds your training and nutrition plan 1:1, and adjusts it as you progress. Start your ascension today at Ascend Coaching.

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This guide is for general education only and is not medical or dietary advice. Results vary from person to person. If you have a medical condition, are pregnant, or have a history of disordered eating, talk to a doctor or registered dietitian before changing how you eat or train.